empowered.vote

ANNUAL REPORT

YEAR OF REPORT: 2025

Empowered Vote, Inc.
501(c)(3) Nonprofit Organization
www.empowered.vote
EIN: 33-1841708

Prepared By:
Peter Torres &
Chris Cantrell

Letter from the Executive Director

At the end of 2024, Empowered Vote became a registered 501(c)(3) nonprofit. We carried that momentum throughout 2025 and with the help of friends and strangers, raised $2,219 for the year in micro-donations. If one day, Empowered Vote handles 22 billion in donations, I suspect I'll still appreciate this 22 hundred more. To anyone who was able to give a couple bucks: Thank You. Those funds went to tools and server infrastructure. We've not, yet, been able to pay a single person, even though many of us met multiple times a week, throughout the year; a labor of love.

In 2025, I found myself in rare company, buoyed by a hope in otherwise dark times, beside a small group of volunteers. Each of us different, but each of us united in the belief that technology should empower our democracy. Year one was about turning that belief into something concrete.

Early in the year, we faced a choice. We could move quickly toward visibility or slow down and focus on foundations. We chose to start with the basics and spent the summer exploring dozens of features, aligning on our focus and establishing our brand identity. In the fall, we launched a new version of the website and turned to the features in the Inform Pillar, and began creating prototypes.

All of this was made possible by volunteers who donated their expertise, early supporters who trusted our direction, and advisors who pushed us to be more rigorous in our thinking. To each of you, thank you.

As we move into year two, our focus is execution. Completing our initial pilots. Stress-testing our assumptions. Beginning fundraising with discipline and transparency. The coming year is about turning groundwork into public value. We invite you to stay engaged, to challenge our thinking, and to help us build civic tools that reward clarity, shared facts, and constructive participation.

Thank you for being part of our first year.

Sincerely,

Chris Cantrell
Executive Director
Empowered Vote

Year One at a Glance

KEY METRICS

501(c)(3) Established

Total Raised : $2,219
(donations + matches)

Total Spent: $825.83

Volunteers: 7–10

Features Prototyped: 2

January–December 2025 · First Full Year

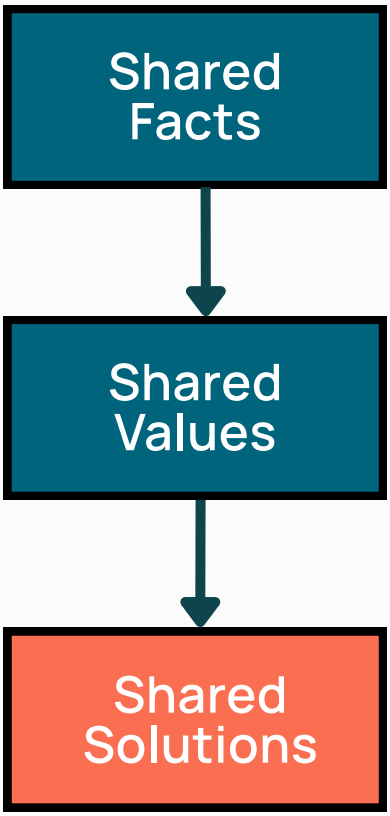
The Problem

Civic tools today reward outrage, speed, and certainty instead of learning, reflection, and shared understanding.

This is a design failure, not a motivation failure

Our Approach

Empowered Vote is designed around a simple belief: Durable civic progress starts with shared facts and shared values.



The Platform

I INFORM

- Evidence-Based
- Engaging
- Anti-partisan

C CONNECT

- Protected Conversations
- Focus on shared values
- Unite around shared solutions

E EMPOWER

- Equity of opportunity
- An amplified Civic Choice
- Paths to enact change

Three pillars, one system

What Year One was about

Our first year focused on building the legal, technical, and organizational foundation required to responsibly launch civic tools at scale.

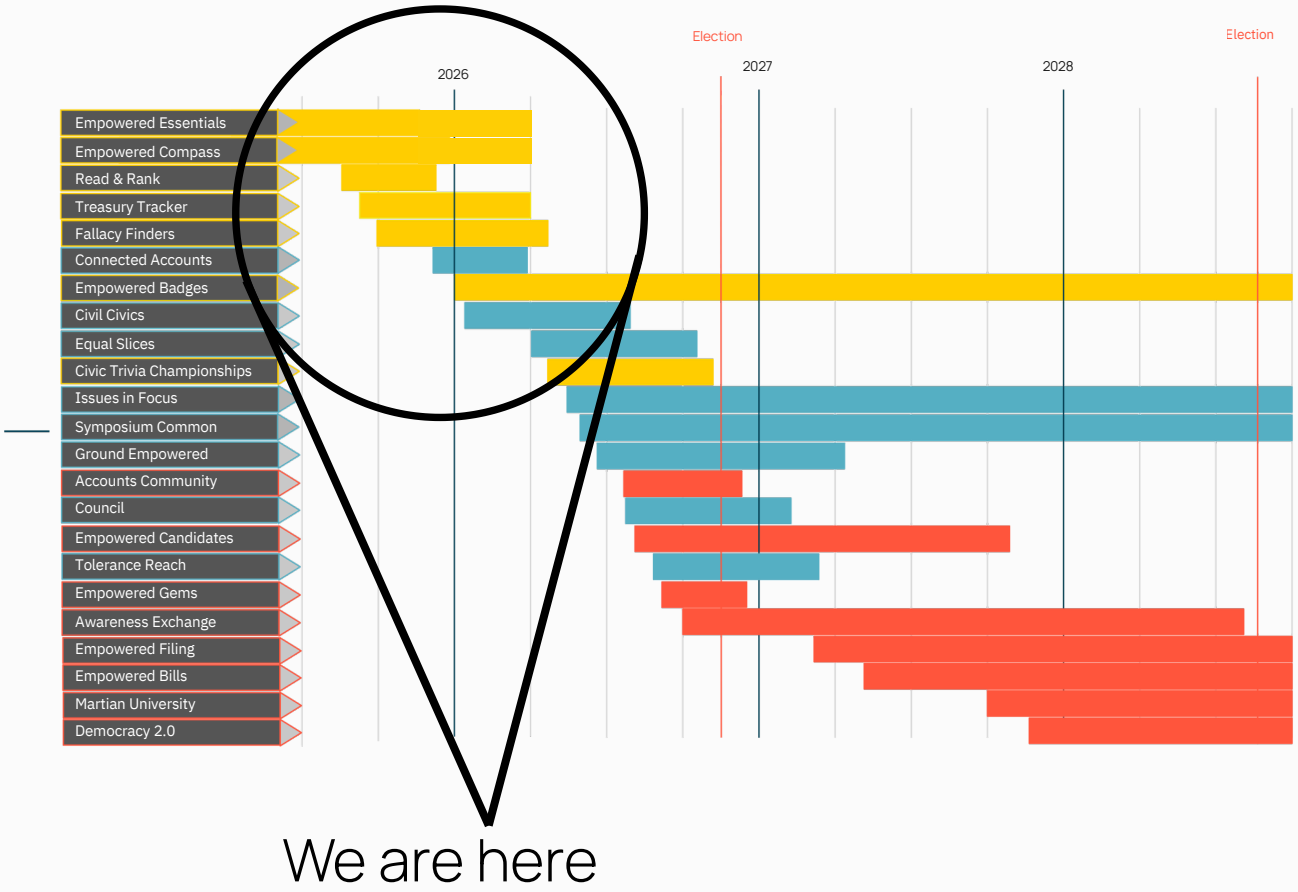
What We Built

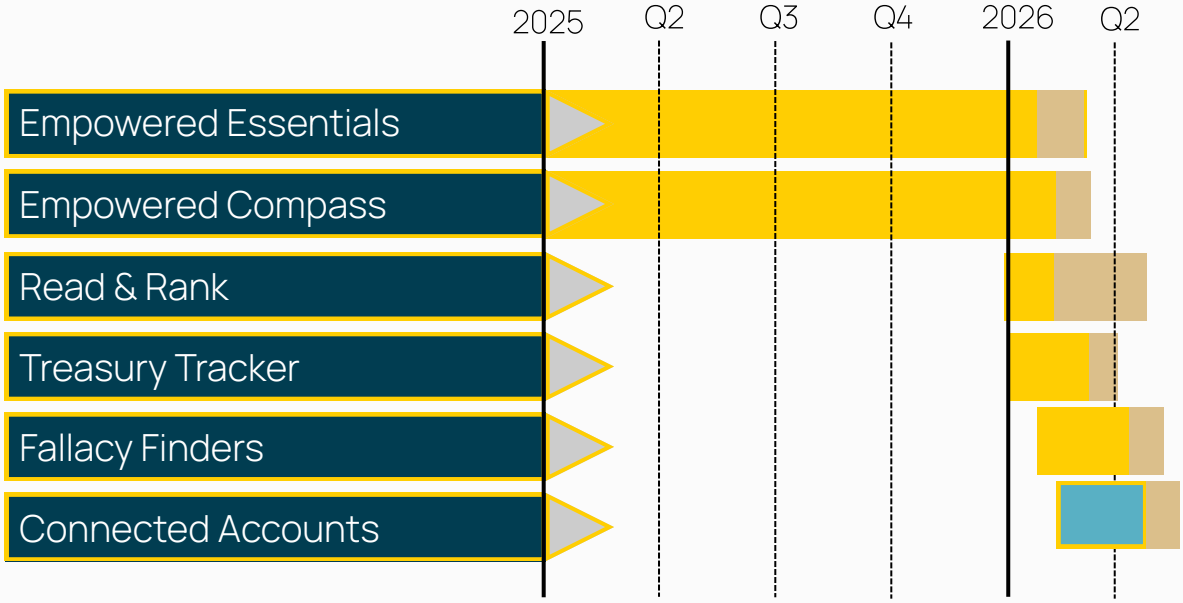
- 501(c)(3) organization and governance
- Core platform architecture
- Updated empowered.vote website
- Early prototypes for Inform tools
- Brand, website, and documentation systems

Foundation before scaling

Project Roadmap

2025 Estimate





Our Team

Empowered Vote is built by 7–10 volunteers, including:

- A game and systems designer
- A solo full-stack developer
- A dedicated UI/UX design team
- A lead researcher focused on human interaction
- Experienced nonprofit, production and political advisors

Volunteer-led, expert-driven

Budget & Spend Analysis

Empowered Vote closed 2025 with strong financial health, generating $2,219 in gross donations while maintaining exceptional efficiency in platform fee management. The organization retained 95% of all donated funds and ended the year with $1,394 in reserves, representing 63% of annual gross donations.

Gross Donations	Efficiency Rate	Ending Reserves
$2,219	95.1%	$1,394

30.7%

Infrastructure

30.7% of total revenue supported technology and coding infrastructure

14.2 %

Workplace Donation

14.2% of donations unlocked through workplace giving programs

89.7 %

Fees

89.7% of donation fees came from Patreon (Opportunity for platform optimization)

4.9 %

Lean Operation

only 4.9% of expenses went to administrative costs

Key Financial Metrics

Financial Overview

Revenue & Expenses

Category	Amount
REVENUE	
Gross Donations	$2,219.00
Interest Income	$1.01
Gross Revenue	**$2,220.01**
EXPENSES	
Software & Subscriptions	$681.47
Office Expenses	$35.00
Platform Processing Fees	$109.36
Total Expenses	**$825.83**
CHANGE IN NET ASSETS	**$1,394.18**

Key Financial Metrics

Efficiency Rate: 95.1% of every dollar donated reached the mission after platform fees
Net Margin: 62.8% (net income as percentage of gross donations)
Operating Expense Ratio: 32.4% of gross donations
Reserve Coverage: Ending balance represents 62.8% of annual gross donations

Fundraising Analysis

Platform Comparison

Empowered Vote utilizes three fundraising platforms, each serving different donor segments and offering unique value propositions:

Platform	Donations	Gross	Fee Rate	Avg Gift
Givebutter	24	$1,334.00	0.24%	$55.58
Patreon	12	$570.00	17.21%	$47.50
Benevity	18	$315.00	2.56%	$17.50
TOTAL	**54**	**$2,219.00**	**4.93%**	**$41.09**

Platform Strategy: Givebutter delivered the lowest fee rate (0.24%) and highest volume, making it the primary platform. Patreon provides recurring donation infrastructure despite higher fees (17.21%). Benevity unlocks corporate workplace giving programs, including volunteer time grants and employer matching.

Workplace Giving Programs

Corporate workplace giving programs generated $315 (14.2% of gross donations) through volunteer time grants and employer matching. This model demonstrates the multiplier effect of engaged supporters whose volunteer hours unlock additional corporate funding beyond personal contributions.

Growth Trajectory

December Surge: $630 in donations (28.4% of annual total), representing a 315x increase over January

Q4 Acceleration: October-December averaged $318/month vs. $119/month annual average
February Campaign: $552 raised demonstrates capacity for focused fundraising drives

Operating Expenses

Software & Technology Infrastructure

Technology expenses totaled $681.47 (95.1% of operating budget), reflecting the organization's civic technology mission. Key platforms included AI tools ($180 for OpenAI ChatGPT), cloud infrastructure ($95.50 for AWS via TechSoup nonprofit program), and collaboration tools.

Software/Service	Annual Cost
Other Software & Services	$405.97
OpenAI ChatGPT	$180.00
AWS (via TechSoup nonprofit program)	$95.50
Total Software & Subscriptions	**$681.47**

Office Expenses

Office expenses totaled $35, primarily covering state filing fees and administrative costs. The lean administrative overhead (4.9% of operating budget) reflects an all-volunteer operational model.

2025 TAX FILINGS

As a certified 501(c)(3) Tax Exempt organization Empowered Vote is required to file taxes annually. Per the IRS requirements, organizations that have gross receipts of $50,000 or less, file 990-N, Electronic Notice (e-Postcard). A copy is presented below for reference.

Form **990-N**

Department of the Treasury
Internal Revenue Service

Electronic Notice (e-Postcard)

for Tax-Exempt Organization not Required to File Form 990 or 990-EZ

OMB No. 1545-2085

2025

Open to Public Inspection

A For the **2025** Calendar year, or tax year beginning **2025-01-01** and ending **2025-12-31**

B Check if available
- [ ] **Terminated for Business**
- [x] **Gross receipts are normally $50,000 or less**

C Name of Organization: **EMPOWERED VOTE INC**
12048 CULVER BLVD APT
210, LOS ANGELES, CA, US,
90066

D Employee Identification Number **33-1841708**

E Website:
https://www.empowered.vote/

F Name of Principal Officer: **BJ Cantrell**
12048 CULVER BLVD APT
210, Los Angeles, CA, US,
90066

Information Copy. Do not send to IRS.

Privacy Act and Paperwork Reduction Act Notice: We ask for the information on this form to carry out the Internal Revenue laws of the United States. You are required to give us the information. We need it to ensure that you are complying with these laws.

The organization is not required to provide information requested on a form that is subject to the Paperwork Reduction Act unless the form displays a valid OMB control number. Books or records relating to a form or its instructions must be retained as long as their contents may become material in the administration of any Internal Revenue law. The rules governing the confidentiality of the Form 990-N is covered in code section 6104.

The time needed to complete and file this form and related schedules will vary depending on the individual circumstances. The estimated average times is 15 minutes.

Note: This image is provided for your records only. Do Not mail this page to the IRS. The IRS will not accept this filing via paper. You must file your Form 990-N (e-Postcard) electronically.

Looking Forward

Financial Sustainability

Empowered Vote enters 2026 with a strong financial foundation: healthy reserves covering 62.8% of annual gross donations, 95.1% platform efficiency, and a validated workplace giving strategy. The December fundraising surge and Q4 acceleration demonstrate growing donor engagement and potential for expanded reach.

Strategic Opportunities

Corporate Partnerships: Workplace giving generated 14.2% of revenue. Expanding corporate volunteer programs could unlock significant matching funds.

Platform Optimization: Patreon's 17.21% fee rate suggests opportunity to migrate recurring donors to lower-cost infrastructure while maintaining convenience.
Year-End Giving: December's $630 demonstrates potential for focused year-end campaigns, a proven strategy in the nonprofit sector.

Operational Efficiency: Technology costs represent 30.7% of donations. Exploring additional nonprofit technology programs (like TechSoup) could reduce infrastructure expenses.

Empowered Vote's 2025 financial performance demonstrates operational excellence, donor loyalty, and strategic platform management. The organization is well-positioned for sustainable growth as it advances its civic technology mission.

The year ahead

- Launch Inform pillar tools
- Begin Connect pillar features
- Expand volunteer & advisory network
- Exponential feature development

Pilot to multi City rollout

The first two Inform features will pilot in Bloomington, Indiana ahead of the 2026 election, establishing the model for expansion into additional cities.

Structured civic dialogue

We will begin development of identity-verified discussion tools designed to move civic conversations from reaction to reflection.

Deepen Capacity and Expertise

We will grow our volunteer base and recruit subject-matter advisors to strengthen research, product design, and governance.

Utilize new tools for rapid coding and iterating

AI tools allow us to move quickly, deploy and iterate based on real world feedback.

From foundation to public launch

Contact Details:

Email: info@empowered.vote
Website: https://empowered.vote